

The Blueprint of a Reclaimed Empire in 1955 Bandung



A bipolar world demanded alignment, but 29 nations chose defiance

The Cold War Ultimatum:
The post-war world order forced emerging nations to choose a side between the US or the Soviets.

TOP SECRET
EYES ONLY

The Third Way:
President Sukarno
gathers 29 African
and Asian nations.

BANDUNG CONFERENCE
APRIL 1955

CRUSHING
PRESSURE PULL

NEUTRALITY / INDEPENDENCE / SOLIDARITY

NEUTRALITY / INDEPENDENCE / SOLIDARITY

RESISTANCE
NOTATION

PROJECT: BANDUNG

TRIG-INFL FLIRE
FACTOR: HIGH

FIG. 1: GEOPOLITICAL FORCES
SCALE: GLOBAL
RESISTANCE FACTOR: HIGH

"No. We choose ourselves."
— The spark of the Non-Aligned Movement.

APRIL 1955

Coloured: Entire
Location

The geopolitical earthquake left a distinct physical footprint across the city



Gedung Merdeka.
The Line in the Sand.



Savoy Homann Hotel.
The Espionage Layer.



Jalan Braga &
Toko Djawa.
The Aftermath.

Bandung Red
walking path

One reclaimed empire.
Three transformative
spaces.

Sukarno turned the ultimate symbol of white colonial privilege into a weapon against it

TOP SECRET:
ARCHITECTURAL DOSSIER

SITE ID: GEDUNG MERDEKA

DECLASSIFIED: BANDUNG
PROJECT: SUBVERSION

ID: GEDUNG MERDEKA

OPERATIONAL INTEL:
SUKARNO STRATEGY

RESISTANCE NOTATION:
HIGH VALUE TARGET

The Origin.
Built exclusively
as a luxury club
for elite Dutch
plantation
owners.



DELEGATE: INDIA

DELEGATE: EGYPT

DELEGATE: GHANA

COLONIAL ERA:
EXCLUSIVE ZONE

LIBERATION ZONE:
BANDUNG 1955

The Subversion.
Sukarno deliberately
selected this space to
host the ultimate
anti-colonial summit,
forcing the birth of
the Third World inside
the very walls of its
former oppressors.

Beneath the Art Deco glamour, an invisible war of espionage waged in the lobby

TOP SECRET:
SAVOY HOMANN FILE

Pure 1939 Art Deco.
The original floor tiles
and furniture remain
today.

The Surface Level:
Global revolutionaries and
celebrities cross paths.
Charlie Chaplin's exact
footsteps.

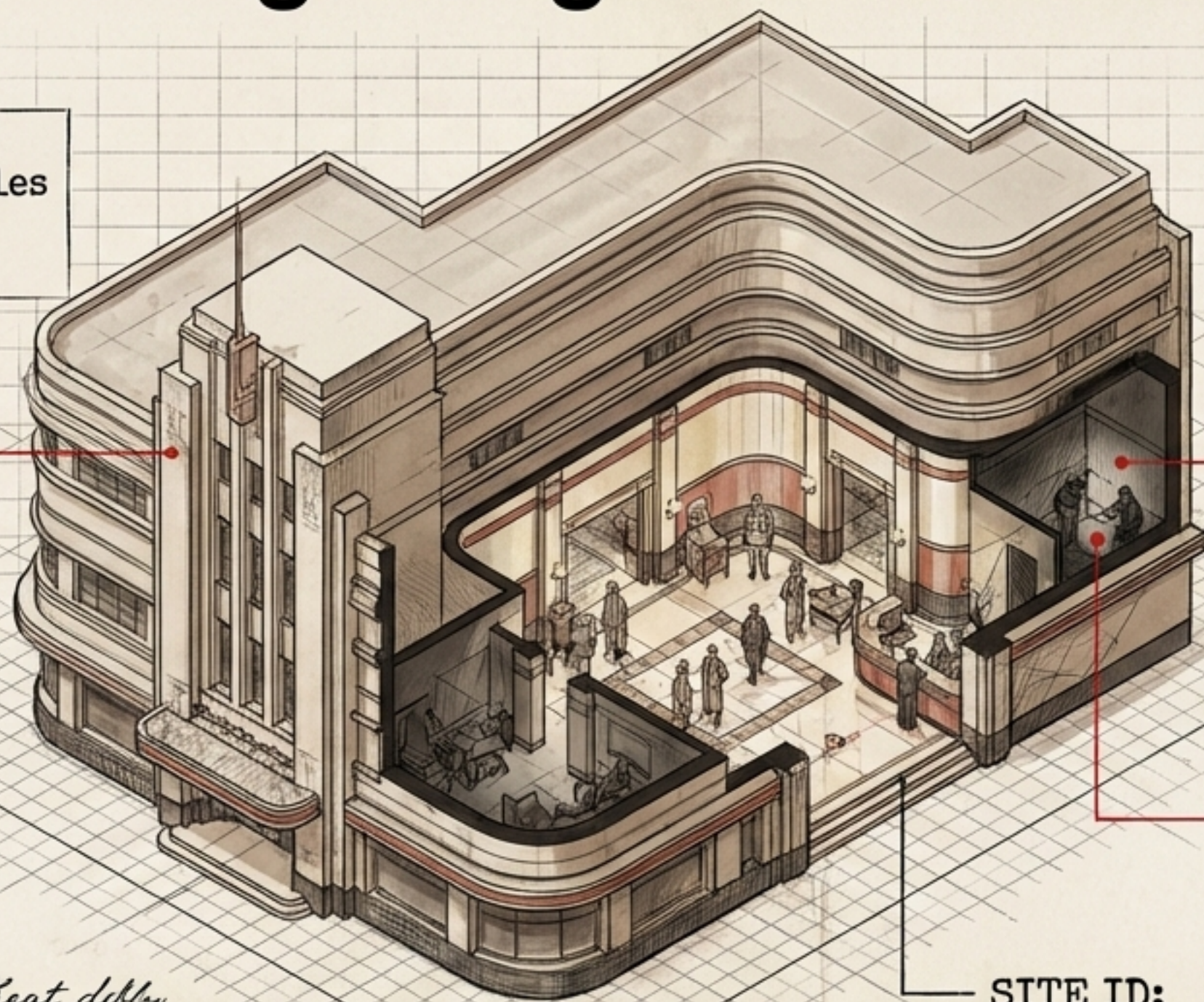
TOP SECRET:
SAVOY HOMANN FILE

The Shadow War: Crawling
with CIA, KGB, and MI6
agents desperately
monitoring the non-aligned
nations to decipher
their plans.

DECLASSIFIED:
ESPIONAGE HUB

*Heat lobby
fronted in the
dossier.*

SITE ID:
THE LOBBY



The Paris of Java traded European elite fashion for local youth culture



DECLASSIFIED:
CULTURAL SHIFT

COLONIAL ERA: JALAN BRAGA

The Paris of Java. Cobbled streets built for Dutch elites to shop for European fashion. We are no longer here for the Dutch.



TRANSITION: ANTIQUE BOOKSTORE

Kopi Toko Djawa spent years operating as a dusty antique bookstore.



RECLAIMED
ZONE

MODERN ERA: KOPI TOKO DJAWA

The space is entirely reclaimed. It now serves as the undisputed heartbeat of Bandung's modern youth culture.

The physical structures remained while the power dynamics were entirely rewritten

TOP SECRET:
SAVOY HOMANN FILE

DECLASSIFIED: CULTURAL SHIFT	The Colonial Era (Oppression)	1955 (The Pivot)	Today (The Legacy)
Gedung Merdeka	Elite Plantation Club	Third World Birthplace	Reclaimed Monument
Savoy Homann Hotel	Luxury Colonial Accommodation	Cold War Espionage Hub	Revolutionary Footsteps Preserved
Jalan Braga / Toko Djawa	Dutch Elite Shopping	(Transitional phase)	Heartbeat of Modern Youth Culture

Across all three spaces, the architecture acts as a vessel. The empire built the walls; the people reclaimed the rooms.

TOP SECRET:
SAVOY HOMANN FILE

A new generation lives and breathes inside the reclaimed shell of an old empire

The legacy of 1955 isn't trapped in history books. It lives in the cobblestones, the hotel lobbies, and the coffee cups.

Order the
Es Kopi Awan.

Bandung stands as a living monument to physical spaces taken back by the people, for the people.